Bowl in Southampton, he assured me, ‘You’re going to have a good week with us. Don’t worry, we’ll look after you.’

I took it all with a pinch of salt, to be honest, but when I walked out to bat, on winning the toss, I was given a standing ovation. The crowd’s warmth was tangible. It suggested that, for no apparent reason, the tide of public opinion had turned. I was still scratching around for runs, like a hen scrabbling in the dirt for scraps, but they cheered me to the echo when I reached 48 by lunch.

Maybe the silent majority had found their voice. Maybe it wasn’t all about shouting from tabloid pulpit and Twitter feed. Maybe, after all the bluff and bluster, people were prepared to take us on our own merits. It was galling to get out for 95, to a good leg-side catch by MS Dhoni off a bottom edge, but a pressure valve had been released.

Ballance and Bell got big hundreds, Jimmy Anderson was man of the match and Mo took six wickets, in the second innings. We were nowhere near the finished article, but momentum was gathering. That 266-run win at Southampton was followed by victories by an innings at Old Trafford and the Oval. When I got home, Alice sensed immediately how much that sequence meant to me. She felt the same, since we had gone through so much together. We made the most of that week’s grace before, once again, I was under the pump.

I was really looking forward to the one-day series against India, as a release from the stresses of the Test summer. I hadn’t been in the best of form but was eager to express myself by playing an attacking innings. There’s nothing like feeling ball on bat. Thanks to good old British rain on a Bank Holiday, I was completely blindsided by criticism from an unexpected source.

The first ODI, at Bristol, was rained off by 1.30 p.m. By that time, Graeme Swann had set the hares running by suggesting on *Test Match Special* that I should quit as one-day captain. Talk became increasingly cheap as we waited for the inevitable abandonment; Michael Vaughan piled in by implying I was doing ‘half a job’ as a batsman.

Bad news travels exceptionally fast. The controversy dominated the news feed on my phone, once I retrieved it from the anti-corruption officers. I understand the need to fill airtime, and the danger of issues being hyped out of all proportion, but when I read Swanny’s tabloid newspaper column the following day I was livid. He had doubled down on the original comments.